Abdullah Al Zahid

Toronto, ON | (780) 982-3680 | azahid1@ualberta.ca | linkedin.com/in/abdullah-al-zahid

October 26, 2026

Talent Acquisition
Engineering & Safety Division
Metrolinx, 20 Bay Street, Toronto, ON

Re: Engineering Lead - Geographic Information Systems (GIS), Job ID 117344

Dear Hiring Manager,

I would like to apply for the Engineering Lead, Geographic Information Systems position in the Engineering and Safety Division. I worked at Metrolinx in 2023 as a Transportation Planner in Service Design, and since January 2024 I have been an Assistant Planner in Transportation Planning at the City of Toronto, where much of my work is building and looking after the spatial data the division relies on.

At the City I build and maintain the road and right-of-way datasets Transportation Planning depends on, using GIS and Python, including a right-of-way width dataset covering all city roads, built with QGIS, MapBox and JavaScript. I also built the Transportation Data Dashboard, which combined several years of Transportation Tomorrow Survey data into one validated source the division now reports from. The posting describes bringing location, condition, performance and project information together so that decisions rest on one consistent picture of the network. That is the problem I have been working on, at the scale of one division.

At Metrolinx I saw the railway from the operations side. I ran OpenTrack simulations of GO rail services to test how infrastructure constraints and speed restrictions changed run times and reliability, and presented that evidence to schedulers, operations staff and engineers. I also set up a command line workflow that pre-simulated slow orders in batches, cutting turnaround on scenario requests from days to hours, and built the Crew Variance Tool, a Python application that read large JSON operations files and summarised speed profiles and run-time variance across subdivisions. My master's thesis used GIS and macro-simulation to assess community transportation capacity for wildfire evacuation, and I took a graduate course in GIS as part of the program.

I should be straightforward about the gaps. I have not led a GIS program or set geospatial governance, standards and data models for an organization; my GIS work has been building and maintaining datasets and tools within one division. I have not worked in asset management or State of Good Repair planning, integrated GIS with an enterprise asset management system, or led staff, consultants or vendors. I am applying because the spatial analysis and data integration at the centre of the role is the work I do now.

Thank you for considering my application.

Sincerely,

Abdullah Al Zahid

Abdullah Al Zahid